

The register slowly spit out the receipt, a quarter inch at a time, calculating the tax and the coupon savings that fills the bottom half of the cash register tape. The cashier announces the final tally and I hear a gasp of surprise from the woman behind me, who'd been rolling her eyes at the delay just a moment before.

Total before coupons: \$230. After coupons: \$38. I'd combined high-value store coupons with manufacturer coupons so that most of the merchandise in my cart was free. The cashier carefully folded the receipt, smiling as she handed it to me. "Great shopping. You saved almost \$200."

"That's what I do," I replied, thanking her for her patience. Then I turned around and handed the customer behind me a stack of coupons for the products she was buying, coupons I'd pulled from my coupon box after some surreptitious glances at her cart.

This is what I do, what I've been doing for more than thirty years.

My question: Why doesn't everyone?